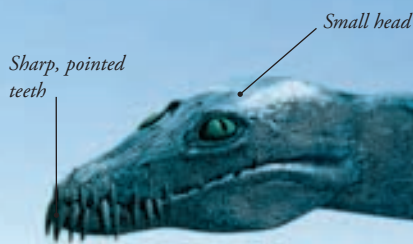


Plesiosaurs

During the Jurassic and Cretaceous periods, when dinosaurs ruled the land, the oceans were ruled by gigantic carnivorous reptiles called plesiosaurs. There were two main types: long-necked plesiosaurs, which had long, snakelike necks and small, dainty heads; and short-necked plesiosaurs (pliosaurs), which had huge heads and enormous, fang-filled jaws.



Elasmosaurus

el-LAZZ-moe-SORE-us



- **When** 99–65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 45 ft (14 m)
- **Diet** Fish, squid, shellfish

Elasmosaurus's neck was as long as the rest of its body. After its discovery in 1868, the first scientists to study this animal thought the long neck was its tail and so put the head at the wrong end. This long neck came in handy—as *Elasmosaurus* swam slowly over the seabed, it would reach down to pick prey off the bottom.

▲ EXPERTS ARGUE over how flexible the long neck of *Elasmosaurus* was. Some think it was as flexible as a snake's body and could be coiled up or held right out of the water. Others think it was stiffer but with enough flexibility to bend down and reach far to each side.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Plesiosaurs had long necks and small skulls; pliosaurs were short-necked, with enormous skulls
- Four large flippers
- Many pointed teeth

When

Plesiosaurs appeared in the Early Jurassic, 200 million years ago. They died out at the end of the Cretaceous Period, 65 million years ago.

Plesiosaurus

PLEE-see-oh-SORE-us

- **When** 200 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** British Isles, Germany
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 10–15 ft (3–5 m)
- **Diet** Fish, squidlike mollusks

Plesiosaurus was a long-necked aquatic reptile with a wide, turtlelike body. Like a turtle, it

pushed itself through the water using its flippers, as the tail was too short to be of much use. It hunted by swimming among shoals of fish, swinging its long neck from side to side to snatch its prey. *Plesiosaurus* had U-shaped jaws, which it could open wide, trapping prey with its conical teeth.

